



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Philadelphia Classical School
School Website: <https://philaclassical.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Philadelphia Classical School (PCS) presents a robust CLASSICAL profile across core rubric categories. The school foregrounds a Christian, classical formation—rooted in gospel faith, the Western intellectual tradition, and the liberal arts—while explicitly committing to virtue formation, engagement with Great Books, and ancient pedagogical practices (grammar, logic, rhetoric) woven into a K–12 program. Public materials emphasize worship, liturgical rhythm, and community formation, alongside a curriculum anchored in the Great Books and unified across disciplines. Notable evidence includes: a mission statement centered on Christ and classical formation; explicit references to teaching the good, true, and beautiful; daily arts integration and liturgical practices (chapel, Christmas programs); a stated portrait of a PCS graduate oriented toward wisdom, virtue, and discipleship; and explicit examples of Great Books, humane letters, and rhetorical training at upper levels. Parental involvement is embedded (volunteer requirements, open houses), and the faculty is described as a living curriculum with a tight-knit, mission-centered culture.

Overall, PCS scores CLASSICAL across all six categories. The public materials closely align with the Positive Keyword indicators in the classical rubric (e.g., truth, goodness, beauty; formation of virtue; Great Books; integration of disciplines; liturgical/community practices; parent partnership in a shared mission). There are clear manifestations of Trivium-focused pedagogy (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Great Books engagement; theology and liturgical life ground the educational project; faculty and parent community are presented as integral to the formation process. See category-by-category sections for explicit keyword matches, evidence, and scoring rationale.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The mission explicitly centers on a gospel-rooted, Christ-centered classical education (Our Mission statement: “rooted in the gospel of Jesus Christ and the historic beliefs of the Church” and “centered in the classical tradition”).
 - Public materials describe graduates as disciplined to know Christ and worship Him, with theology and church formation integrated into the education (Portrait of a Graduate: “disciplined to know Christ, worship him as their Savior, and embrace his body the Church”).
 - Recurrent liturgical/communal cues: chapel routines, Christmas program, and other faith-based gatherings referenced in public pages (e.g., Christmas Program, Grandfriends/Grandparents events); chapel rhythm in School Information page.
 - Ad Fontes posture appears in school materials, signaling a return to foundational sources in a Christian/classical framework.
 - The tag line “Nurturing students to love the good, the true, and the beautiful.” signals transcendentals in action (truth, goodness, beauty) within a liturgical/true-good-beauty frame.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: gospel of Jesus Christ; Christ-centered; worship; divine relationship; liturgical/chapel; truth, goodness, beauty; grand religious formation; devotion to Christ and the

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- Church; Ad Fontes.
 - Negative keywords: none evident in materials (no explicit “secular ethics,” “value-neutral,” or dismissal of theology are present).
 - Quantitative sense (approximate): 6–8 positive-identity terms clearly present; 0 negative terms found in the public materials analyzed.
 - Why this rating
 - PCS publicly anchors its identity in Christian theological foundations, liturgical life, and formation through faith, which maps squarely to Transcendental moral realism, Grounded theology, and Liturgical/communal practices criteria. The explicit theology-informed mission and worship/catechesis signals strongly that religious/metaphysical foundations are central, not peripheral.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Mission describes formation of intellect, virtue, and spiritual life with leadership/service aims, not merely job preparation: “fostering intellectual, moral, and spiritual virtues so that students are prepared to lead and serve in any vocation or calling” .
 - Portrait of a Graduate emphasizes formation of mind and heart (discipleship, wisdom, virtue) with a commitment to truth and beauty in a Christian classical frame .
 - Language around “liberal arts education” and long-term cultivation of wisdom aligns with classic aims beyond technical training, including the cultivation of wonder and virtue (as reflected in mission-oriented language and materials) .
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: virtue, wisdom, formation, character, lifelong wisdom, truth/goodness/beauty; leadership/ service; formation over mere information.
 - Negative keywords present: none (no explicit focus on “career-readiness” or “workforce prep” over formation).
 - Approximate frequency: multiple positive keywords clearly used; zero negative keywords detected.
- Why this rating
 - The school foregrounds formation (virtue, wisdom, character) and a transcendent purpose (truth/beauty) over material/occupational schooling. The explicit formation/character goals and the emphasis on serving leadership align with CLASSICAL.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Strong Great Books orientation: explicit engagement with primary sources and canonical texts (e.g., Epic of Gilgamesh; The Iliad; The Republic; The Divine Comedy; Summa Theologica; etc.) as part of the Humane Letters reading and senior thesis structure ; Selections from the Humane Letters Reading List list includes major Western canon works .
 - Interdisciplinary/harmony of subjects: Humane Letters and classical canon integrated across history, literature, philosophy, and theology; explicit Great Books emphasis and cross-textual engagement visible in course listings (Humane Letters, Classical Rhetoric, etc.) .
 - Liberal arts framework evident in upper-level course names (Humane Letters II–VI; Classical Rhetoric; Summa Theologica junior thesis; etc.), indicating Trivium/Quadrivium orientation and rhetoric as core skills .
 - Ad Fontes and classical posture appear as curricular stance (focus on classic sources and source-based inquiry) .
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, primary sources, classical curriculum, cross-disciplinary integration, humane letters, classical rhetoric, historical canon, sacred texts, unity of truth across disciplines.

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- Negative keywords present: none from the classical rubric (no explicit modern skills-first or test-centric, no wholesale replacement of Great Books with modern curricula).
 - Approximate frequency: multiple strong matches to positive curriculum keywords; no negatives observed.
 - Why this rating
 - The curricular design is deeply aligned with classical education in content (Great Books, primary sources), method (humane letters, rhetoric, debate/oral expression), and structure (integration of disciplines, history-driven canon). The presence of canonical works, classical rhetoric, and a long-standing liberal-arts emphasis justifies CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Lower School: pedagogy emphasizes contemplative, restful elements and memory-friendly practices (chanting and singing, regular review, delight in learning) in line with classical pedagogy's memory and reverence for learning (pedagogical nostalgia for scholé/recall, and memory work in early years) .
 - Upper School: Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and explicit rhetoric training in upper grades (e.g., Humane Letters II–VI, Classical Rhetoric, junior thesis, senior thesis) signaling dialectical inquiry and public speaking as core methods .
 - The overall approach emphasizes formation through integrated, classical methods (grammar/logical thinking, rhetoric, and public speaking; engagement with heavy texts; structured discussion) as described in the mission and curriculum pages .
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: scholé/contemplative learning; memorization and chanting; singing in lower school; Socratic discussion; seminars; rhetoric training; public speaking.
 - Negative keywords present: none evident (no strong mention of project-based-only, purely worksheets, or non-classical pedagogies).
 - Approximate frequency: multiple explicit pedagogical markers align with classical methods; zero counter-indicators.
- Why this rating
 - The pedagogy shows foundational classical practices (Scholé-type contemplation in early years; Socratic/seminar/rhetoric work in upper years) consistent with the Classical School rubric.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Faculty described as model teachers and mentors who form the “living curriculum” and act as the core of the school; quotes from faculty emphasize virtue, intimate knowledge of students, and a collaborative, familial faculty culture .
 - The staff-page framing underscores a culture of partnership, mentorship, and shared mission (the living curriculum) as central to PCS's approach .
 - The presence of formal leadership and teacher roles across K–12 with specialized heads (Lower School Head, Upper School Head) demonstrates structured faculty leadership aligned with classical formation .
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; model teachers; mentors; core of the school; faculty as partners; mission-aligned professional community; teacher as exemplar; portrait of teacher/student ideals.
 - Negative keywords present: none evident.
 - Approximate frequency: multiple clear positive indicators; no negative indicators.
- Why this rating
 - The materials present a cohesive, value-driven faculty culture where teachers are central to the curriculum and the educational formation of students, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Active partnership with families is foregrounded (parents as co-teachers; explicit callouts to parent involvement; volunteer requirements; parent-community activities) .
 - The school encourages parental engagement via open houses and involvement in events; the admission process emphasizes a personal, family-centered application path; communication is ongoing through events and community blog activity (e.g., parent-community discussions) .
 - The school positions itself as a family-centric, church-connected community with a history of parent involvement (e.g., blog and staff engagement) in the PCS ecosystem .
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; co-educators; parent involvement; home–school collaboration; parental engagement; community of learners; parent formation; school visits/open houses.
 - Negative keywords present: none evident (no “parental disengagement” or “parent-friendly” cautions required; rather, the site emphasizes robust parental involvement).
 - Approximate frequency: frequent occurrences of positive keywords; no negative indicators.
- Why this rating
 - PCS treats parents as co-educators and actively invites parental involvement, aligning with the classical rubric’s emphasis on family partnership and shared mission.

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall, PCS demonstrates a consistent CLASSICAL orientation across all six categories. The school aligns with transcendental aims, virtue formation, liberal-arts curriculum, classical pedagogy, a teacher-centered/mentor-driven faculty, and an engaged parent-community ecosystem. The presence of Great Books, the Trivium-based curricular signals (grammar, logic, rhetoric) in upper grades, liturgical life, and explicit Christ-centered formation strongly support CLASSICAL status.

What would move the needle

- For a strictly CLASSICAL classification, no major needle-moving changes are required. If anything, further explicit, public articulation of Socratic seminars in K–8 (where applicable) and a formal display of the Trivium progression (grammar–logic–rhetoric) across more grade bands could sharpen the public-facing alignment, though current materials already indicate substantial classical pedagogy.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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